6.3.| CORE LESSON – MOVING ON

At this point in the session, the focus shifts to the future. The programme ending can be a very emotional time for participants. Many may feel anxiety about the next chapter in their lives. It is important to provide families with some support and encouragement.

The next activities help families identify ways of continuing to support one another.

"Stone Soup" is a story about community building that is shared with the families to help them take ownership of their own skills, knowledge, and each other!

Depending on how much time is available and whether there is a separate celebration planned, you may want to tell this story during the community celebration.

STORY – STONE SOUP

(traditional tale as narrated by Jamie McLaren Lachman)

> There was once a beautiful village. The people of this village were always happy because they never needed anything. They had livestock, fruits, and vegetables, as theirs was a very fertile village. They never knew suffering.
>
> However, after some time there was drought. There was no more rain and their livestock was dying. Times became difficult because now there was

hunger in the village. The people stopped talking to each other because everyone was focusing on their own problems.

One day an old woman came to this village carrying a big black pot on her head and a small brown bag. When she arrived in the middle of the village, she placed the big black pot on the ground and sat next to it to take a rest. No one saw this woman, except a little boy who was out playing that day.

When the boy saw this old woman, he asked her "What are you doing with that big black pot?"

"I am going to make some Stone Soup!" answered the old woman. This confused the boy. Who ever heard of such a thing as Stone Soup?

Because he was a curious boy and always full of questions, he asked, "Can I please help you?"

The old woman was very happy when he asked to help. "Of course, you can! Go and get some water and collect some wood, my child," she said.

So, the boy collected some wood in the nearby forest. As the old woman was busy making the fire, he went down to the river to fetch some water.

By the time the boy returned with water, the old woman had a large, warm fire burning.

She placed the big black pot on the fire and poured in the water. She then opened her small brown bag and took out a shiny, round white stone. She placed it in the big black pot and began to stir, humming an old cooking song.

Soon, the water began to boil. The old woman licked her lips and said to the boy, “Mmmmm…this is going to be a delicious pot of Stone Soup.”

It wasn’t long when the others began to notice the fire burning in the middle of the village. One by one, they left their homes to see what was happening.

"What is going on here?" asked one man. The boy answered, "She is cooking Stone Soup!"

Those who were there exchanged looks as if they had never heard of such a thing. Stone Soup?

The news spread fast and throughout the village. All the villagers left their homes to see this crazy old woman and her Stone Soup with their own eyes. As the people were arriving, the old woman continued to stir the pot while humming.

When she noticed that that there were many people gathered, she stopped stirring and tasted the watery soup. "Mmmmmmm… This is going to be the most delicious soup. It is just missing something. If only there were some onions…”

One woman had a few old onions that she had been saving. They were small and wrinkly but still good to eat. “I have some onions,” she offered. She fetched them from her home, chopped them up, and added them to the big black bubbling pot.

After a little while longer, the old woman tasted the soup again. “Yes, this soup is going to be so good. But it is missing something…. If only there were some more….”

"Vegetables!" said a voice from the crowd, "It needs more vegetables. I have some spinach. It's not much but you can use it." Another person brought a couple of old potatoes. Someone else had a cabbage. Another garlic. Carrots. A pumpkin. Salt. An old scrawny chicken. Some chillies. Spices.

[At this point, the storyteller can ask people for suggestions what to put in the soup]

The smell of the soup filled the village. It reminded people of the old days. They began to talk to each other, exchanging stories and news, even jokes. Laughter was heard again for the first time in many years.

At last, the old woman stopped stirring. She tasted the soup and declared with a twinkle in her eye, "This Stone Soup is nearly ready. And so much to eat. I wonder if you will help me finish it please."

Everyone went back to his or her homes and brought bowls and spoons. Even though there were so many people, there was just enough for each person. They ate the soup until they were all full. And it was the most delicious Stone Soup they had ever tasted.

When they were done, the villagers brought out their drums and other musical instruments and began to sing songs and dance. They sang and danced until dusk. Then, the villages thanked the woman and returned to their homes chatting with each other. Once again, there was the sound of laughter and song in the air that evening.

As the evening stars began to shine, the old woman was left alone in the middle of the village. She gathered the white stone in her small brown bag

and placed her big black pot on her head. Without a word of farewell, she slowly began to walk down the windy road that led out of the village.

Before she could leave, the boy saw her and ran to her. "Why are you leaving?" he asked.

“My work here is done,” the old woman replied. “But we need someone like you to help us,” said the boy.

She reached into her small brown bag and handed the boy the white stone. “You have all the ingredients that you need to make Stone Soup.” Then she slowly walked down the road. The boy watched and waved until he couldn’t see her any longer.

The villagers never saw that woman again. But life in the village continued to thrive – in the best of times and the worst of times they never lost their connection to each other again as they continued to make the most delicious Stone Soup.

The end.

DISCUSSION – KEEPING THE MOMENTUM GOING

Lead a discussion to help participants to identify specific ways in which they can continue to support each other. Useful questions to help prompt discussion may include:

1. What are some of the ingredients that we have in our community to continue supporting us as families?
2. In what ways can we continue to support our children's development and our lives after the programme?

You can suggest that someone takes the responsibility for getting the group together if participants suggest staying in contact or continuing to meet regularly.

For peer support groups, it is important to identify the following:

- Person (or people) responsible for organizing the support groups
- Decision about how to meet: Online? In person? If so, where and when can families meet?
- Can help be provided by an organisation?

REVIEW – TIPS FOR CONTINUING SUPPORT:

1. Keep practicing all the Parenting Tips that you used
2. There may be other families who have done the Mayor Konektà programme in your neighbourhood. Start your own Parent Support Group!
3. Learn what services and support you can get in your community.